



△ The god Anubis mummifies a corpse, painting at Tomb of Amennakht

c. 2686–2181 BCE

## MUMMIFICATION DEVELOPED

In the Egyptian Old Kingdom (c. 2686–2181 BCE), the bodies of the pharaohs, their families and other nobles, were preserved by a process of mummification, embalmed and wrapped in cloth, before being entombed with a wealth of funerary treasures.

3000 BCE

c. 3000 BCE **The Elam civilization** emerges along the eastern side of the Persian Gulf

c. 2560 BCE **The Great Pyramid of Giza**, tomb of the pharaoh Khufu, is completed

c. 3000 BCE **Construction of Stonehenge** begins on Salisbury Plain in the west of England

c. 2600 BCE **The first stepped pyramids** are built in Caral, the major city of the Norte Chico civilization, Peru

c. 2900 BCE

## CUNEIFORM WRITING SYSTEM

The Mesopotamians of Sumer devised a method of recording transactions by making impressions in soft clay with a stick. These simple tally marks developed into a sophisticated writing system using wedge-shaped (cuneiform) symbols to represent words and syllables, rather than the pictograms used in hieroglyphics.



△ Clay tablet with cuneiform inscription



2334–2279 BCE

## SARGON THE GREAT OF AKKAD

Through his conquests of neighbouring kingdoms, Sargon extended his rule from Akkad (east of the Tigris), becoming the first leader to rule over an empire of subject city-states.

“Only the gods dwell forever in sunlight.  
As for man, his days are numbered.”